

► **Women of state**

Prime Minister Sirimavo Bandaranaike of Sri Lanka (left) meets with Indian Prime Minister Indira Gandhi, (right) in 1976. Gandhi's close relationship with Bandaranaike moved the latter's politics to the left.



Australia but could not yet stand for election. Since then, over 70 countries—including the UK, France, Canada, New Zealand, Thailand, the Philippines, Brazil, Poland, Mozambique, Argentina, Australia, and Ukraine—have had female heads of government or state. Several women have served as political leaders on the Indian subcontinent too. In 1960, Sirimavo Bandaranaike became the world's first elected

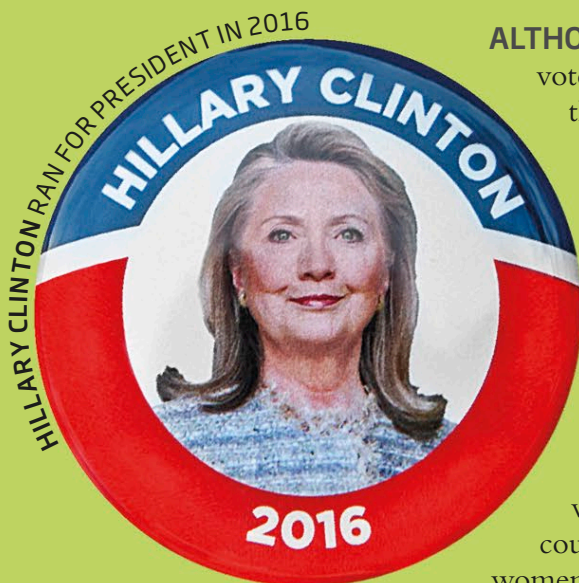
“In times of **crisis**, **women** eventually are **called upon** to sort out the **mess**.”

CHRISTINE LAGARDE, 2014

THROUGH THE AGES

Politics

Historically, relatively few females have held powerful positions in politics, but since the 1960s the numbers have steadily increased. Although women are yet to approach parity with men as influential global figures, they have made notable progress in the last 50 years.



ALTHOUGH WOMEN WON the right to vote in most democratic nations by the mid-20th century, today they still lack equal representation in political office. The average proportion of female members in national-level parliaments (that admit women) is 23.3 percent. Rwanda is a key exception; in 2008, it became the first nation with a female parliamentary majority.

The 1907 elections in Finland were the first in which women could run for national office. By then, women had the vote in New Zealand and

female head of government as Prime Minister of Sri Lanka; six years later Indira Gandhi was elected Prime Minister of India, the world's largest democracy. Gandhi served until 1977 and was reelected in 1980. She was assassinated in 1984. No woman has spent longer as head of government. Bangladesh has had a female prime minister for nearly three decades, with Khaleda Zia holding power for two five-year terms, and Sheikh Hasina Wazed leading the nation from 1996–2001, and 2009 to the present day.

The Nordic states have led the way for gender equality in politics. Although Sweden is yet to elect a female head of government, Swedish women have some of the highest